

A photograph of two young children, likely toddlers, in a room with light-colored walls and a wooden floor. The child on the left is seen from the back, with short, wavy brown hair, wearing a dark vest over a white long-sleeved shirt. The child on the right is facing slightly towards the camera, with short brown hair, wearing a similar dark vest over a white shirt. The text "Do children have a sense of self?" is overlaid in black font on the upper left portion of the image.

Do children have
a sense of self?

T/Th 9:35-10:25am

Professor Casey Lew-Williams

Kennedy Casey, Abby Fergus, Sarah Joo, Chantal Valdivia, Claire Whiting

Media/art project

- Open-ended creative assignment
- Create anything you want (tiktok, music, art, performance, poem, game...) as long as it's somehow related to a topic or theme from this course.
- Work with students FROM YOUR PRECEPT — something like 1 to 5 other people. Importantly, every single person must demonstrate engagement.
- Present your mini-project **FOR 5 MINUTES OR LESS** in the last precept of the semester
- Email the project to your preceptor (if it's email-able... otherwise just present/perform it during your precept)

3 bullet points

- Submit 3 bullet points on the three things you found the most interesting from this course
- Due on Canvas on the day of your last precept
- Reminder: please remember them forever



1. Early awareness of self and others

2. Fixed vs. Growth mindsets

3. Self-esteem and resilience

Self/Other differentiation



The Rouge Test: Self-Recognition

Self-awareness: Halloween study

- Kids who see themselves in a mirror are more likely to follow the rules and take just 1 piece of candy.



...but only if they're known by the person who lives there

Theory of mind

- Understanding that others have minds and can perceive/ believe different information from you
- Understanding how the mind works and that mental states influence behavior
- This requires representing others' beliefs, thoughts, and knowledge
- How do we test theory of mind?

A test of theory of mind



(Gopnik & Astington, 1998)



PHOTO: MARIO TAMA/GETTY IMAGES

Fixed vs. Growth mindsets

Fixed mindset vs. Growth mindset

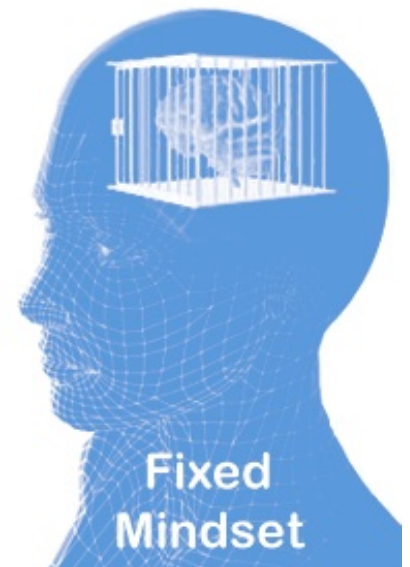
(a.k.a., entity vs. incremental theory of intelligence)



Professor Carol Dweck

Fixed mindset (a.k.a., 'entity theory')

- The belief that our character, intelligence, and creative abilities are static; can't change them in any meaningful way.
- Success is the affirmation of inherent intelligence, an assessment of how our static abilities measure up against an equally fixed standard.
- Striving for success and avoiding failure at all costs becomes a way of maintaining the sense of being smart or skilled.



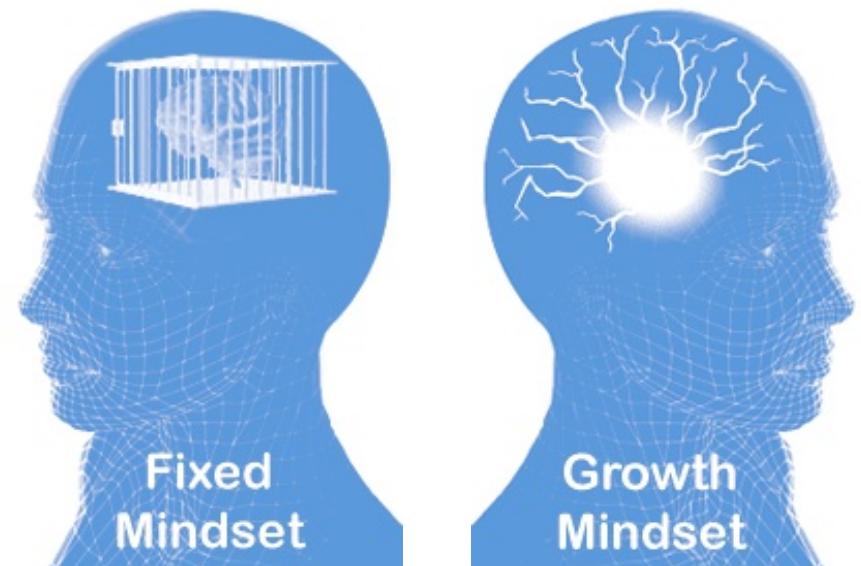
Growth mindset (a.k.a., 'incremental theory')

- The belief that our character, intelligence, and creative abilities can be developed through dedication and hard work.
- See failure as motivation for growth and for stretching our existing abilities (not as evidence of unintelligence)



Fixed mindset vs. Growth mindset

- Praising **'innate' abilities** (i.e., overemphasizing intellect or talent) leaves people vulnerable to failure, fearful of challenges, and unwilling to remedy their shortcomings.
- Praising **effort** (i.e., emphasizing that intelligence is malleable and can be developed through education and hard work) promotes perseverance and academic success



Fixed mindset vs. Growth mindset



Fixed mindset vs. Growth mindset

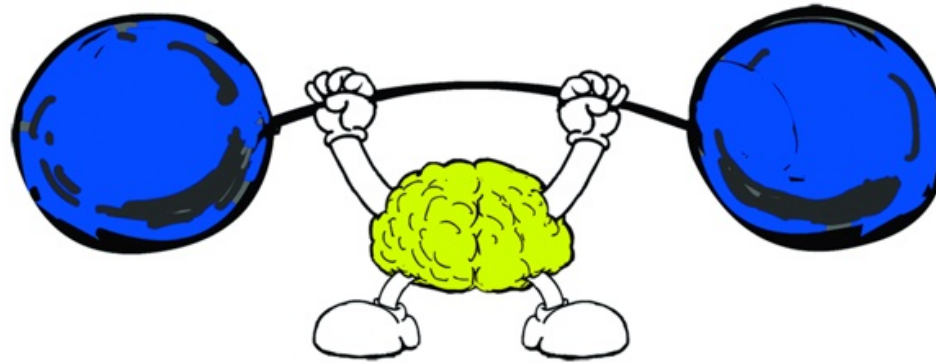
I think intelligence is something you have to work for... it isn't just given to you... Most kids, if they're not sure of an answer, will not raise their hand to answer the question. But what I usually do is raise my hand, because if I'm wrong, then my mistake will be corrected. Or I will raise my hand and say, 'How would this be solved?' or 'I don't get this. Can you help me?' Just by doing that I'm increasing my intelligence.

- 7th grader



Fixed mindset vs. Growth mindset

- Blackwell et al. (2007)

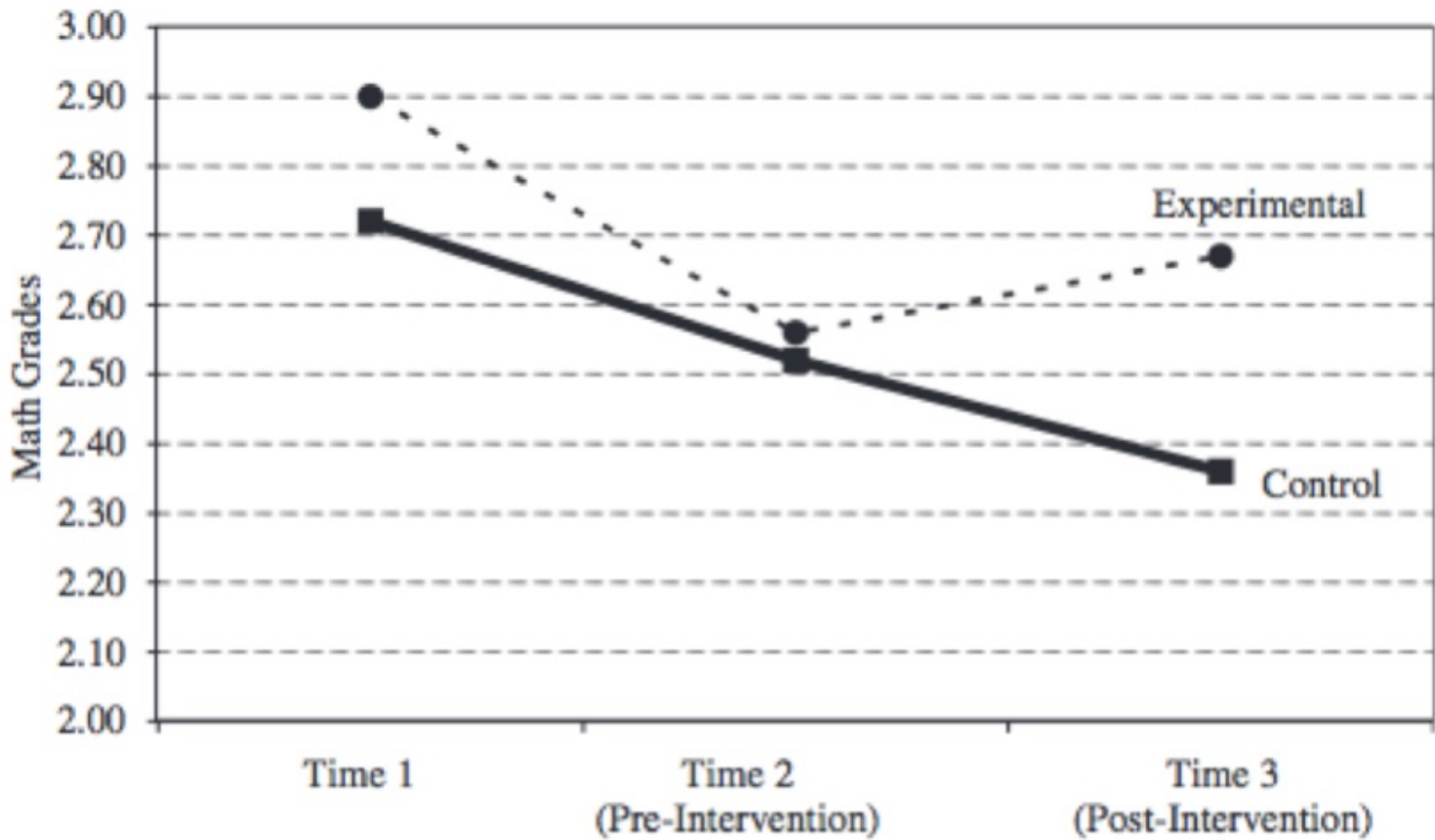


- Growth mindset = better grades
- Why?
- Intervention study



Fixed mindset vs. Growth mindset

- Blackwell et al. (2007)



More interesting findings

- In a study with 170,000 10th graders in Chile, mindsets predicted academic achievement just as strongly as family SES!
- Children who are told they have a reputation for being smart are more likely to cheat.
- Growth-minded individuals show superior accuracy after making mistakes.
 - An ERP study probed the neural mechanisms underlying different reactions to mistakes. The growth mindset was associated with enhancement of an area of the brain that allocates attention to mistakes.

More interesting findings

- In order to be implemented successfully, students' growth mindsets must be supported by their teachers' growth mindsets.



More interesting findings

- Origins of learned helplessness?

One day you played with the blocks and built a great big tower. When playtime is over, the teacher, Mrs. Billington, says, “Will you stack up the blocks for me?” and you say “OK, teacher.” And so you start to put the blocks over where they are supposed to go, and you begin stacking them up. You really want to do a good job, but when you look down at what you did, you think to yourself, “Uh-oh, the blocks are all crooked and in a messy pile,” but you worked hard to put them all away, and you say to the teacher, “Mrs. Billington, I put the blocks away.” The teacher looks at the job you did and says, “The blocks are all crooked and in one big mess.”

Then, **person** feedback vs. **process** feedback

More interesting findings

- Origins of learned helplessness?

One day it was play time and your teacher, Mrs. Billington, said, “[child’s name], would you make a puzzle for me?” And you said, “OK teacher, I’ll make the puzzle for you.” So you sat down at the puzzle table and started to put the pieces together. First you found the corners, and then you started to put the side pieces together. After that you fit the center pieces all in. You wanted to show the teacher the puzzle you made, and so you said “Teacher, I made the puzzle for you,” and you looked back at the puzzle you made and thought to yourself “Yep, I put all the pieces of the puzzle together.” When the teacher, Mrs. Billington, came over and saw the puzzle you made she said, “That puzzle has all the pieces put together.”

Then, **person** praise vs. **process** praise

More interesting findings

- Subtle linguistic cues affect children's motivation
 - Generic praise: *You're a good drawer.*
 - Nongeneric praise: *You did a good job drawing.*



How Not to Talk to Your Kids

The inverse power of praise.

By **Po Bronson** Published Aug 3, 2007 [Share](#)

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(Photo: Phillip Toledano; styling by Marie Blomquist for I Group; prop styling by Anne Koch; hair by Kristan Serafino for L'Oreal Professionnel; makeup by Viktorija Bowers for City Artists; clothing by Petit Bateau [shirt and pants])

What do we make of a boy like Thomas?

Thomas (his middle name) is a fifth-grader at the highly competitive P.S. 334, the Anderson School on West 84th. Slim as they get, Thomas recently had his long sandy-blond hair cut short to look like the new James Bond (he took a photo of Daniel Craig to the barber). Unlike Bond, he prefers a uniform of cargo pants and a T-shirt emblazoned with a photo of one of his heroes: Frank Zappa. Thomas hangs out with five friends from the Anderson School. They are "the smart kids." Thomas's one of them, and he likes belonging.

If You're Open to Growth, You Tend to Grow
By JANET RALE-DUPREE
Published: July 6, 2008
The Perils and Promises of Praise
Carol S. Dweck

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"If you manage any people or if you are a parent (which is a form of managing people), drop everything and read *Mindset*."
—Ger Kanawson, author of *The Art of the Start*

mindset

THE NEW PSYCHOLOGY OF SUCCESS

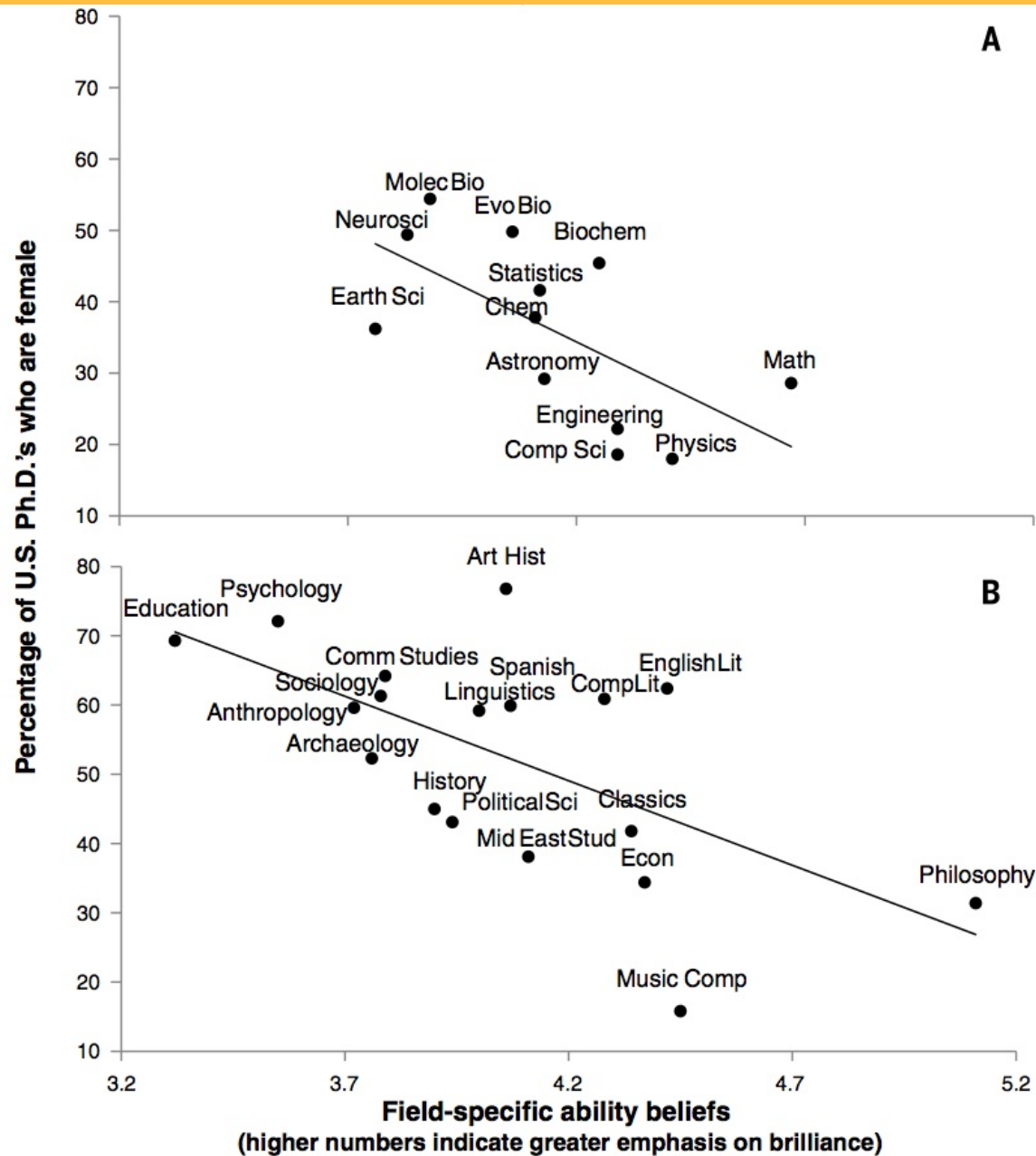
HOW WE CAN
LEARN TO FULFILL
OUR POTENTIAL

*parenting
*business
*school
*relationships

CAROL S. DWECK, Ph.D.

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Mindsets & academia



Do expectations of 'brilliance' underlie gender distributions in academic disciplines?



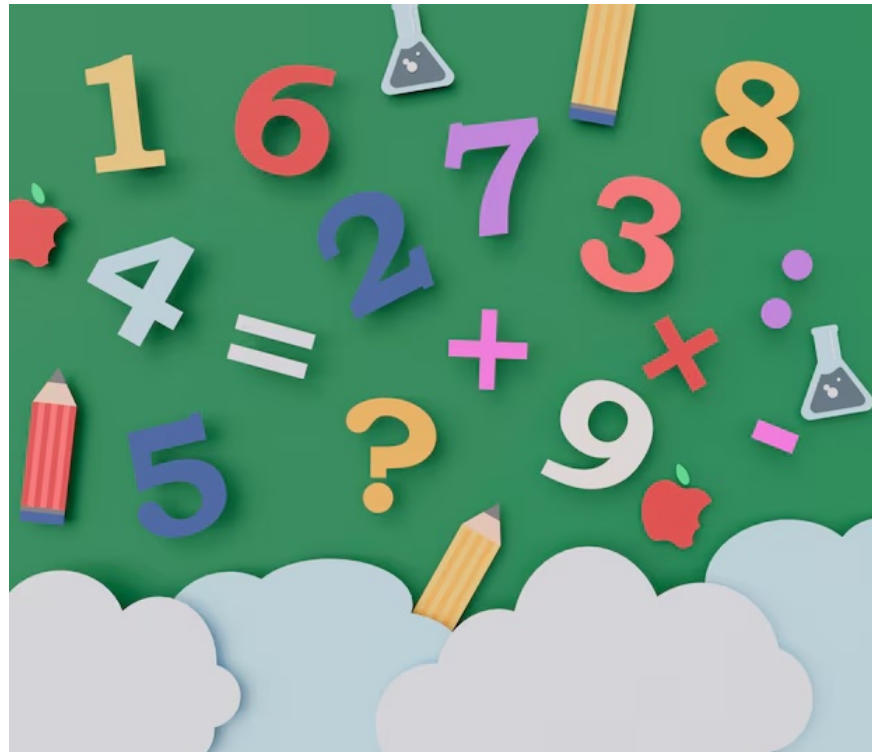
Fig. 1. Field-specific ability beliefs and the percentage of female 2011 U.S. Ph.D.'s in (A) STEM and (B) Social Science and Humanities.

Mindsets & academia

Elementary school girls (on average) think you have to be “really, really smart” to do well in math (compared to reading/writing).

This is related to lower math motivation.

Small differences in beliefs become big differences in outcomes.



TWO MINDSETS

CAROL S. DWECK, Ph.D.

Graphic by
Nigel Holmes

Fixed Mindset

Intelligence is static



Leads to a desire
to look smart
and therefore a
tendency to...

CHALLENGES

...avoid
challenges



OBSTACLES

...give up
easily



EFFORT



Growth Mindset

Intelligence can be developed



Leads to a desire
to learn and
therefore a
tendency to...

...embrace
challenges



...persist in the
face of setbacks



EFFORT

...see effort as
fruitless or worse



...see effort as
the path to mastery



CRITICISM

...ignore useful
negative feedback



...learn from
criticism



SUCCESS OF OTHERS

...feel threatened
by the success
of others



...find lessons and
inspiration in the
success of others



As a result, they may plateau early
and achieve less than their full potential.

All this confirms a **deterministic view of the world.**

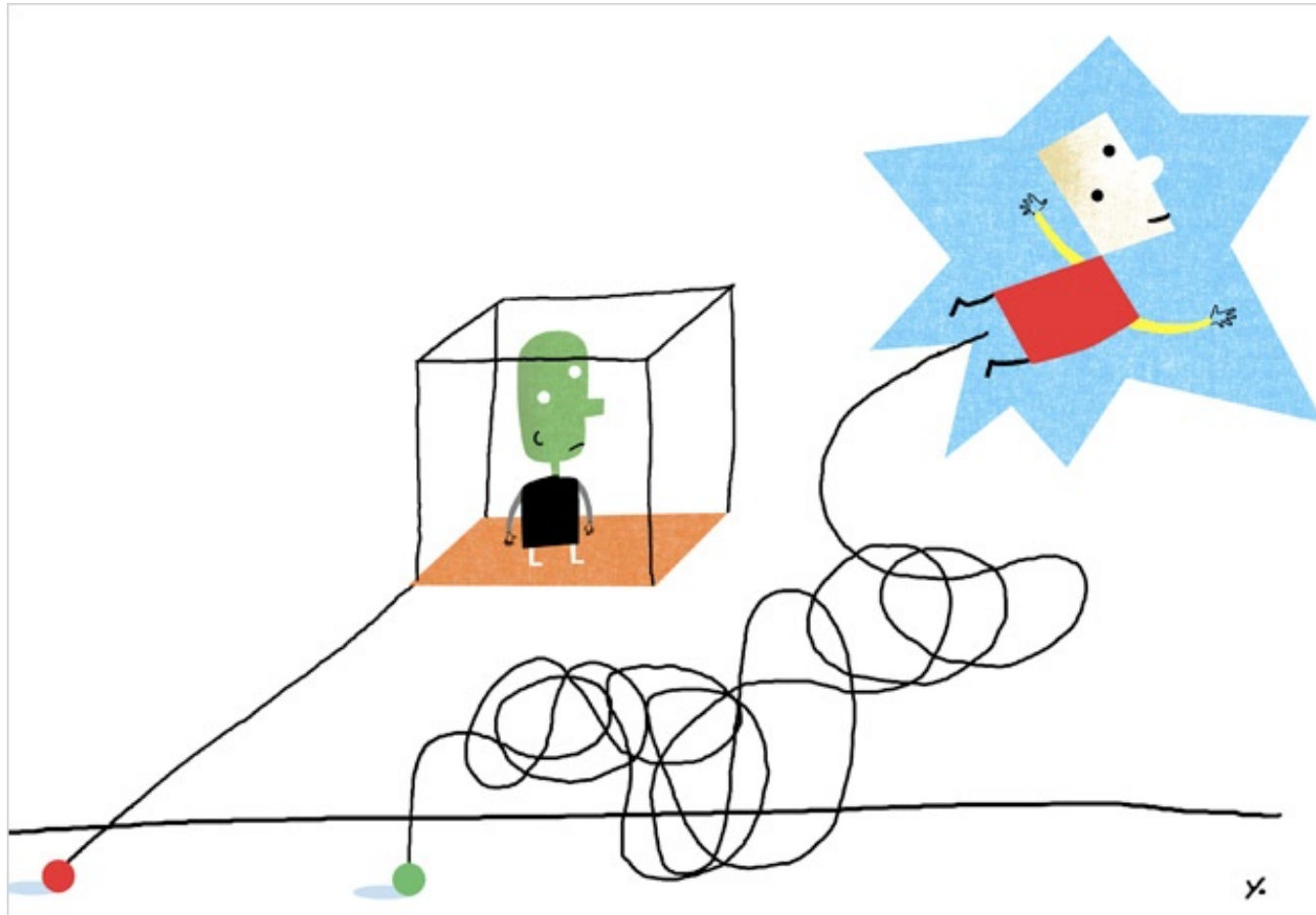
As a result, they reach ever-higher levels of achievement.

All this gives them a **greater sense of free will.**

Mistakes are so interesting. Here's a wonderful mistake.

Your English homework was hard, but you stuck with it, and you stayed at your desk and concentrated. That's great.

Wow, this is hard. This is fun.



SKEPTICISM

Does it make sense to think in a binary way like this? (*no*)

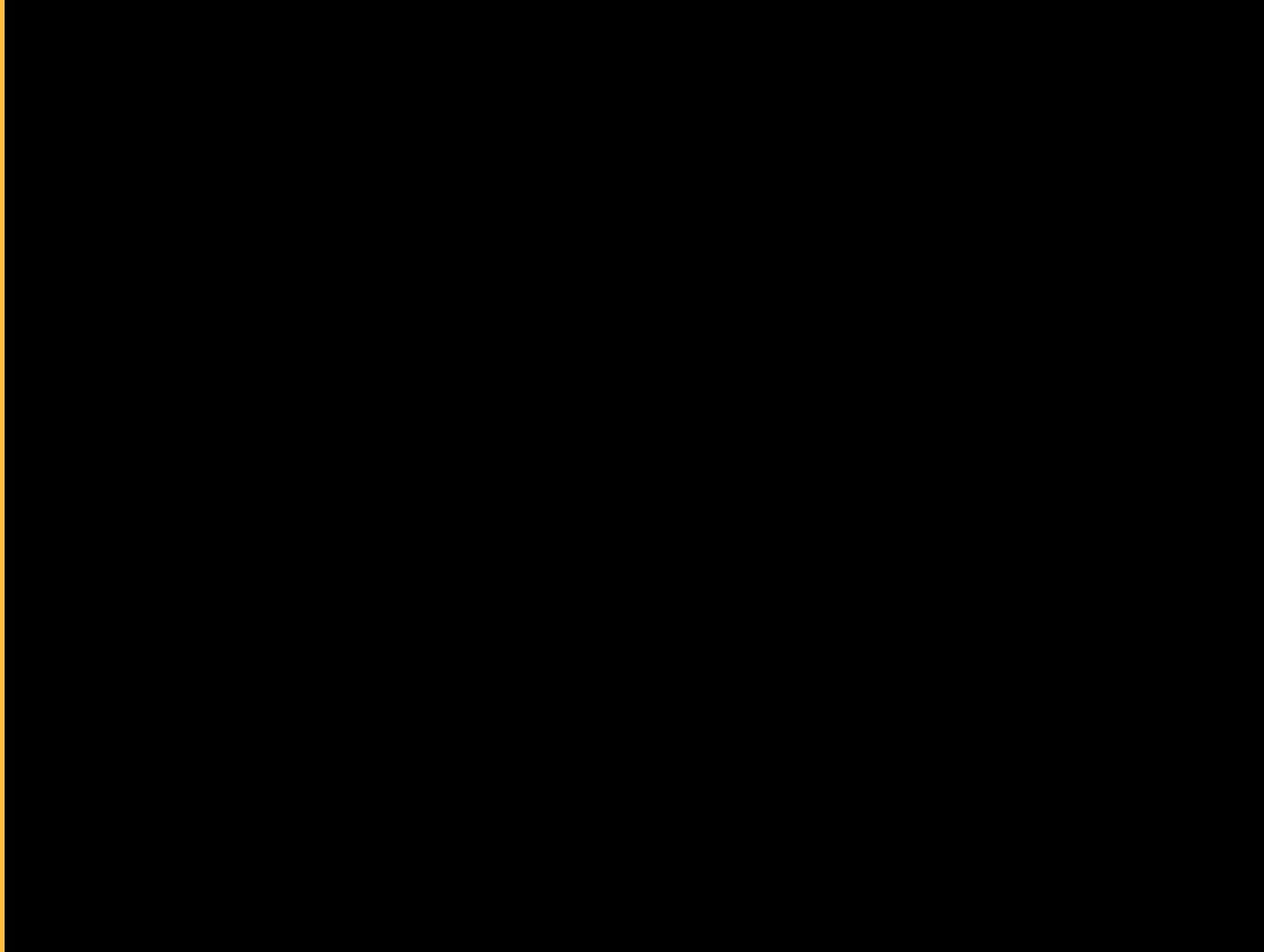
Might our mindsets differ in different contexts? (*yes!*)

Is the fixed mindset categorically bad? (*no!*)

Isn't a fixed mindset kind of useful in some ways? (*yes!*)

Isn't it okay to be lazy and not try to thrive all the time? (*yes!*)

Self-Esteem



Self-esteem

- The evaluative component of self that taps how positively or negatively people view themselves in relation to others.
- Global vs. individual areas of self-esteem:
 - Scholastic competence, social acceptance, athletic competence, physical appearance, behavioral conduct...

Self-esteem

- Development
 - Children under 8 tend to rate themselves very positively in all domains, & later become more realistic
 - Start to differentiate abilities in different areas
- What determines self-esteem?
 - Parenting styles, feedback from peers, teacher/mentor support...
- Why should we care about self-esteem?
 - Correlational studies show a relation between low self-esteem in childhood and later problems
 - Interventions can improve self-esteem and other outcomes

Resilience

(we don't know enough about this!)

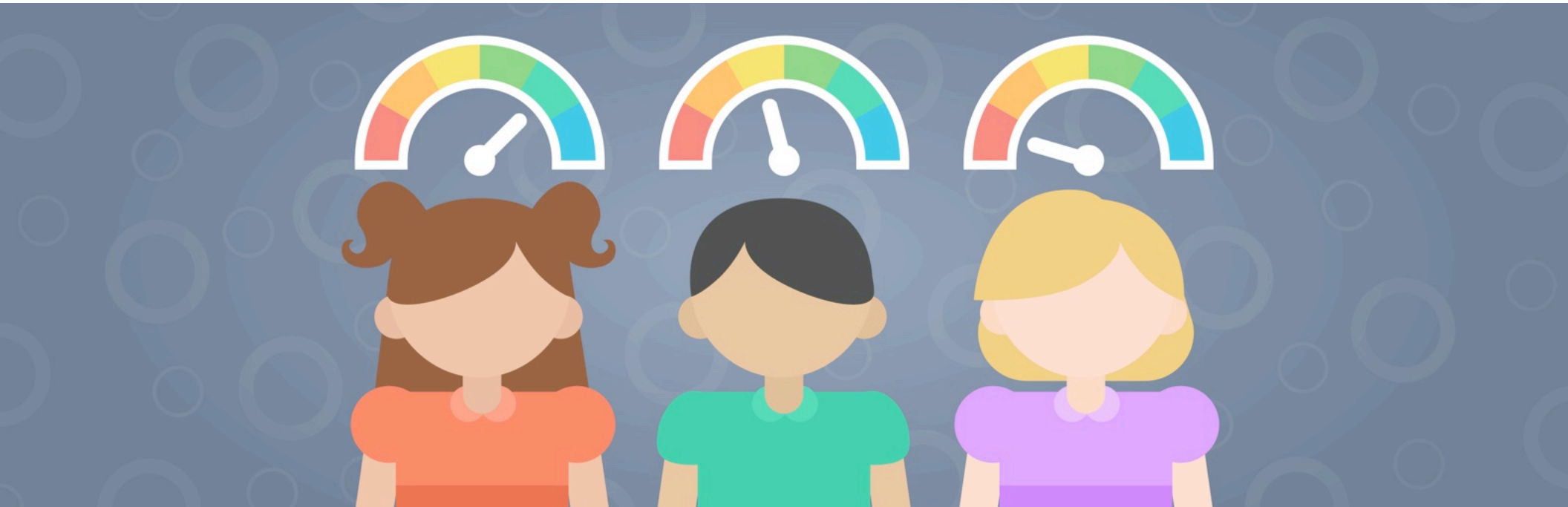
Resilience

- Study of entire 1995 birth cohort on Kauai: 698 infants
- Found that more risk factors = more problems
- But 1/3 of high-risk children displayed resilience and became caring, stable, and confident adults.
- Protective factors?



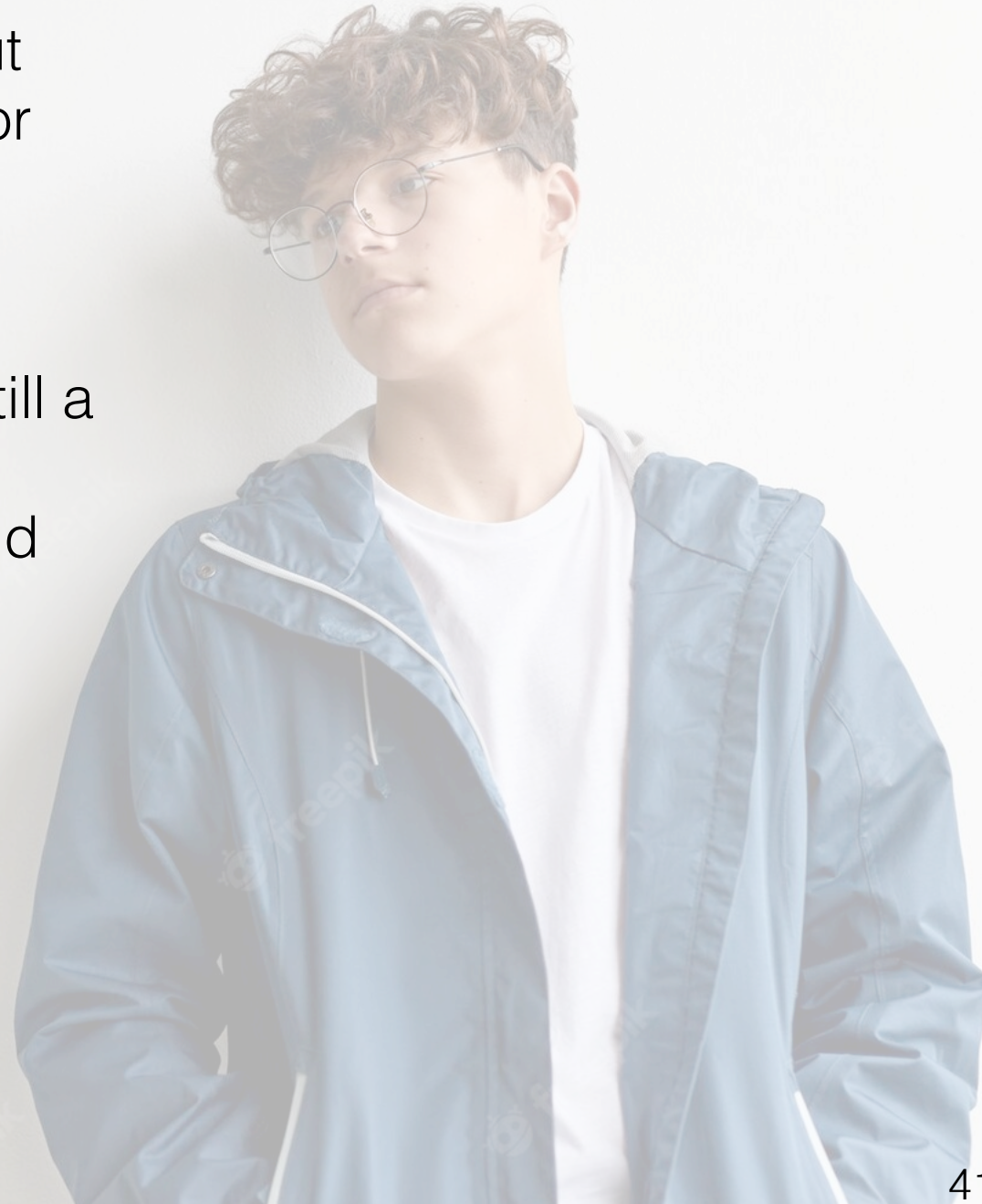
Resilience and mental health

- **Stable, supportive caregiving** is an important protective factor against negative outcomes (e.g., psychopathology) in the context of early adversity.



The complexities of studying resilience

- Is resilience a trait that hangs out with you throughout childhood, or that emerges from your experiences?
- Does a supportive caretaker instill a sense of resilience? Or did that person step up *because* the child sort of 'has what it takes'?



The complexities of studying resilience

- Does it take just factors X and Y to enable resilience, or does it take a special recipe of factors?
- Is there a recipe at all? Can you even begin to generalize one kid's experience to another kid? Is rising above an abusive household the same thing as rising above a high-crime neighborhood?
- Also, what even is resilience? Grit? Perseverance? Flexibility?



The fact remains that getting people right is not what living is all about anyway. It's getting them wrong that is living, getting them wrong and wrong and wrong and then, on careful reconsideration, getting them wrong again.

- Philip Roth, novelist, *American Pastoral*